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FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

At the India Today Conclave in 2003, former US President Bill Clinton had said: "I have no doubt India will be a giant. But what kind of giant? You must become a global giant and the right kind of giant." What does being a global giant mean, and what is the right kind? India is already a giant in many respects: the largest population, the fifth largest economy, the seventh largest in physical size and, above all, the world's largest democracy. President Clinton quite likely implied, 'Not a global giant like China'. A country that is autocratic at home and practises 'wolf warrior' diplomacy abroad. How can India become the right kind of global giant? The answer depends on what we mean by the question. A global voice other nations pay heed to? Superpower status? An economic powerhouse?

The current government's ambition is to create a Viksit (developed) Bharat by 2047. We seem to be on the right path to achieve this goal. Even through nasty global recessions, we have held on to a healthy growth rate of 6.5 per cent since the mid-1990s. Plain continuity will convey us upward: being the third largest economy is within sight. But we do not want mere inertia of motion. We must attain freedom from want, indignity and an inferior life for our hundreds of millions. That will begin the real expansion of our capabilities and enable us to become the right kind of global giant.



This special I-day issue pares down the gargantuan challenges confronting India into 10 keystone areas. Articles by our editorial team, organised thematically, lead to an ensemble of guest essays from the best minds in their respective sub-fields, 29 in all, who approach different facets of the challenge. Think of it as a collectively authored script for India—an expert roadmap for the future.

Having such a blueprint is essential. We are perhaps the only country which straddles many centuries together simultaneously, from subsistence farming to some of the most advanced rocketry in the world. For the most part, these layers don't hang well together; they stay like oil and water. A genuine growth model for India will seek to integrate these components and make them work in tandem. History can often be an instruction manual for how not to do things. Our early decades invite the criticism that they kept the animal spirits of entrepreneurship under a tight leash and relied too heavily on inefficient government entities to deliver. We are a nation of entrepreneurs whose power needs to be released by the government. As we reset our priorities for 2047, one thing is certain: no part can be kept waiting till the others are sorted out. The vanguards of growth cannot be forgotten till the rear is fortified, and vice versa. Everything must move together, synergistically.

The first imperative is to have an action plan to ensure we have sustained GDP growth—8 per cent annually must be the floor, not the ceiling, for the next two decades. Secondly, that self-propelled engine will move on world-class infrastructure. Our freight of ambitions needs physical conduits—a latticework of high-speed rail and expressways, ports and airports, linking us with each other and with world markets. Also, neural networks of the digital kind to convey ideas and information. Such a foundation will enable the third step: India leapfrogging to Industry 4.0, where manufacturing and services function at the cutting edge of global standards to create jobs and prosperity. What must our industrial landscape look like? Author-industrialist Naushad Forbes says we should "seek a future that looks like Germany, with thousands of specialised world leaders, rather than China or South Korea, with a few dozen giant state-sponsored champions". In this beehive model, India will maximise the world's new 'Plus One' strategy and harness AI to its fullest. That leads to the fourth prerequisite: critical and emerging technologies incubated in our own R&D labs to not just keep pace with the world but to lead it.

Technology is a universal enabler and recurs as a leitmotif in all sections. For instance, space technologies are typically dual-use and mark a zone where India is poised to be a world leader. In the terrestrial realm, where a secure country needs to be an impregnable fortress, we find satellite imagery segueing with cutting-edge drones, submarines and missile systems for both geospatial surveillance and interception. But weather predictions link space to another earthly preoccupation: agriculture. In this keystone project, we must wean farmers away from their addiction to traditional grain crops, and scale up their per capita productivity by a decisive shift to horticulture, dairy and fisheries. The key is to reform our agriculture to align with market forces, without which we cannot become a developed nation. No growth model will make sense if we neglect our staggering inequalities. Amit Kapoor, Chair at the Institute for Competitiveness, writes, "India's GDP per capita, a true indicator of a nation's prosperity, is $2,730 (approx. Rs 2.3 lakh)...much lower compared to our developing bloc peers, including Brazil ($11,350), China ($13,150), Vietnam ($4,620) and South Africa ($5,970)." India's G20 Sherpa Amitabh Kant pegs the target per capita income at $18,000+ (upwards of Rs 15 lakh) in three decades.

They are not alone in seeking a refocusing of India's agenda away from the poverty line to what I call the dignity line. It has two key building blocks: education and healthcare. Some 35 per cent of our children are stunted—thus prone to cognitive deficits and poor learning outcomes. Alongside, we have an ironic double whammy. While malnutrition stalks the base of the pyramid, an epidemic of lifestyle diseases—diabetes, cancer, cardiac problems—imparts a disturbing twist to India's health challenge. That too, when the scourges of the past, like tuberculosis, persist. So, the lack of quality universal literacy marks us against the 'miracle' economies of Southeast Asia, and a sickly nation cannot be a world leader even if we can look forward to being the pharmacy of the world. The ninth imperative extends that to the health of our habitat: our air, water and soil. The greening of our economy is a precondition to all else, with decarbonisation built into growth.

Milestones make you think along two cardinal directions. Looking back at the journey so far is a natural impulse. But that's only a complementary act to thinking ahead, even if it seems like plotting one's steps in the dark. The following pages hold deep, incisive takes from a galaxy of domain specialists on how we must chart our path—from a NASA scientist to former defence chiefs, industry leaders and technology savants and top names in nuclear, aviation, higher education, et al. In the end, the tenth segment is what will get the world to doff its hat to us: India's soft power. Yoga, culture, wisdom traditions. That unique amalgam of the past and the contemporary must give us the freedom of ambition.

Happy Independence!

(Aroon Purie)

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**